U.S. Immigration Trends and Policy Context

How did China's immigration pathways and asylum grants differ from broader U.S. and Asian patterns?

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Introduction

This report examines how China's routes to U.S. permanent residence, refugee arrivals, and asylum grants compare with U.S. and Asian patterns. I use six tables from the OHSS 2022 Yearbook, covering a long immigration series (1820–2022) and focused comparisons for FY2013–2022. In a Jupyter notebook, I used Python and pandas to reshape tables, calculate counts and shares, and combine affirmative and defensive asylum grants; I made the figures with Plotly. The purpose is to identify where counts and shares diverge and discuss their timing alongside U.S. immigration policies, without treating timing alone as evidence of causation.

Three patterns stand out: employment preferences accounted for 44.9% of China born new permanent residents in FY2022 versus 26.5% nationally; Asian refugee arrivals fell faster than U.S. arrivals in FY2016–2018; and China's share of Asian asylum grants fell from 63.2% to 32.2% between FY2013 and FY2022.

Data and Methods

Table 1 placed four year and count pairs side by side; I stacked them into one 1820–2022 series, removed trailing empty rows, and converted years and counts to numbers. For table 2, I selected the U.S. total and China rows and transposed the year columns into observations. I selected the total, Asia, and China rows from table 10d to compare FY2022 admission classes.

For table 14d, I transposed the total, Asia, and China refugee rows into FY2013–2022 observations. I joined affirmative and defensive asylum rows from tables 17d and 19d by fiscal year, then added them for U.S., Asia, and China grant totals. A share is a subgroup count divided by its matching total, multiplied by 100: for example, 62,022 / 1,018,349 = 6.090% for China by last residence in FY2022; 7,524 / 22,405 = 33.58% for Asian refugee arrivals in FY2018.

I kept "D" as withheld rather than treating it as zero. Table 2 uses last residence; table 10d uses birth; refugee and asylum tables use nationality. Historic country observations are decades through the 2010s, followed by individual years. The policy sources below help interpret timing, but this analysis does not test causal effects.

Long Run Lawful Immigration

Annual permanent residence grants contracted in the 1930s and generally reached higher levels after the mid twentieth century; FY2022 recorded 1,018,349 grants.

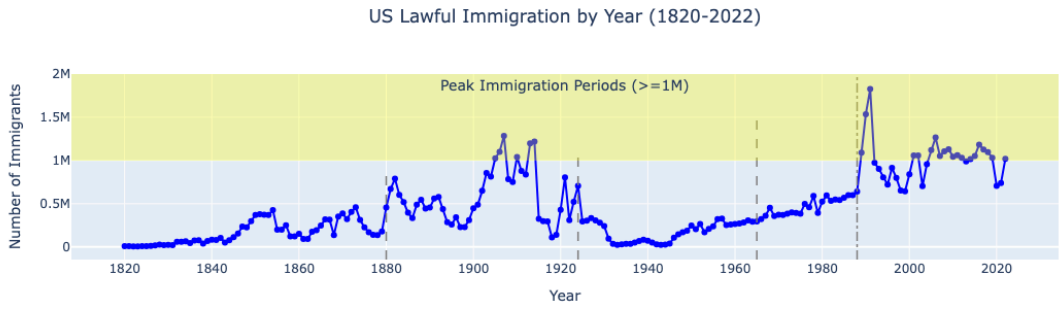


Figure 1. U.S. annual lawful permanent residence grants, FY1820–2022. Notebook Figure 1, based on OHSS table 1. The yellow band marks the 1–2 million range on the vertical axis.

The 1924 national origins quota law and the 1965 law that ended that quota system provide context for the broad change in the series. The 1880 line is a historical period marker and 1988 is a project defined break, not a policy intervention

tested here. The chart also reflects wars, economic conditions, and processing changes, so its turning points cannot be assigned to one law.

China and U.S. Permanent Residence

Observation	China count	U.S. total	China share
1870s	133,139	2,742,137	4.855%
1880s	65,797	5,248,568	1.254%
1890s	15,268	3,694,294	0.413%
1900s	19,884	8,202,388	0.242%
1920s	30,648	4,295,510	0.713%
1930s	5,874	699,375	0.840%
1970s	17,627	4,248,203	0.415%
1980s	170,897	6,244,379	2.737%
FY2021	48,072	740,002	6.496%
FY2022	62,022	1,018,349	6.090%

Table 1. Permanent residence grants by China as last residence, selected decades and FY2021–2022. Counts and shares from OHSS table 2; decade totals and single years have different durations.

China's count fell from 133,139 in the 1870s to 15,268 in the 1890s, while its U.S. share fell from 4.855% to 0.413%. The Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882 restricted Chinese labor immigration during this span. Its timing matters, but these decade totals cannot measure the law's effect on their own.

Counts and shares can also diverge. From the 1920s to the 1930s, China's count fell from 30,648 to 5,874, yet its share rose from 0.713% to 0.840% because the U.S. total fell even faster. The 1924 quota system and the Great Depression are relevant context, not separate effects identified by this table. After the 1965 repeal of national origins quotas, China's count rose from 17,627 in the 1970s to 170,897 in the 1980s; the data alone do not explain the size of that change. In FY2021–2022, China's count rose again, while its share fell from 6.496% to 6.090%.

FY2022 admission class

Table 10d uses country of birth: 67,950 China born people obtained permanent residence in FY2022, or 6.67% of the U.S. total and 16.38% of the Asia born total. Table 1 counts 62,022 by last residence. The 5,928 difference reflects distinct classifications, not a discrepancy to reconcile as the same group.

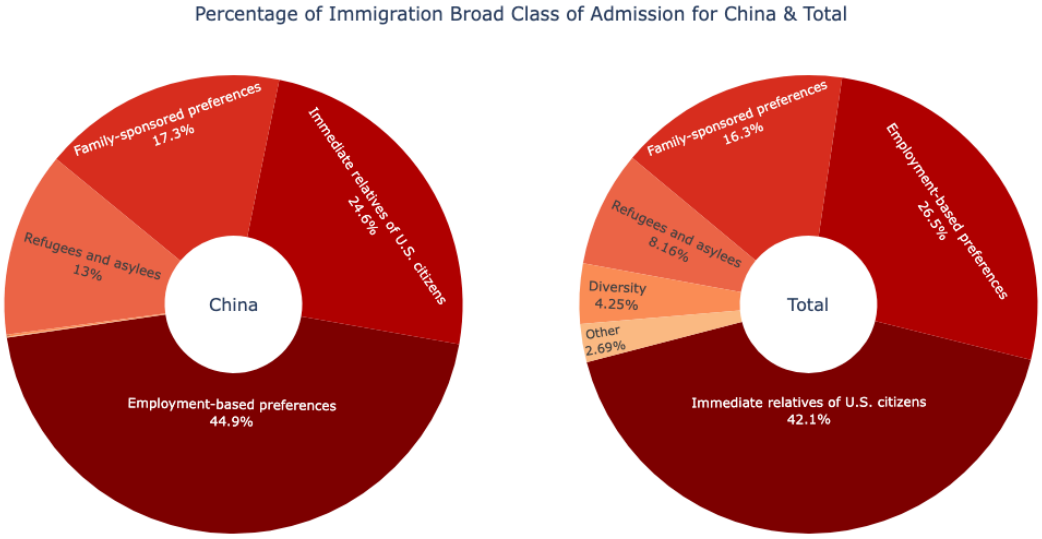


Figure 2. FY2022 admission class mix for China born and all new U.S. permanent residents. Reproduced from notebook Figure 4, using OHSS table 10d; each slice is a share of its own group.

The class mix is different: employment based preferences lead for China (30,514 / 67,950 = 44.9%, versus 26.5% nationally), while immediate relatives lead nationally (42.1%, versus 24.6% for China). The 1965 law established family and skill preferences, but it does not by itself explain the FY2022 difference between groups. Refugees and asylees are 13.0% of China born new permanent residents versus 8.2% overall; this counts later residence grants, not that year's refugee arrivals or asylum grants.

Asylum Grants in the United States

Nationwide asylum grants rose to 45,805 in FY2019, fell to 16,628 in FY2021, then recovered to 36,615 in FY2022. Affirmative grants led through FY2021; defensive grants led in FY2022 (22,481 versus 14,134). The chart's bars show total grants and its lines separate the two routes.

USCIS returned to a last in, first out interview schedule for affirmative cases in 2018. It also paused routine in person asylum office services in March 2020, and reported that distancing affected FY2021 affirmative completions. Those changes make processing conditions relevant to the trend. Grant totals do not include the application cohort or decisions denied, so they cannot quantify either policy's effect or an approval rate.

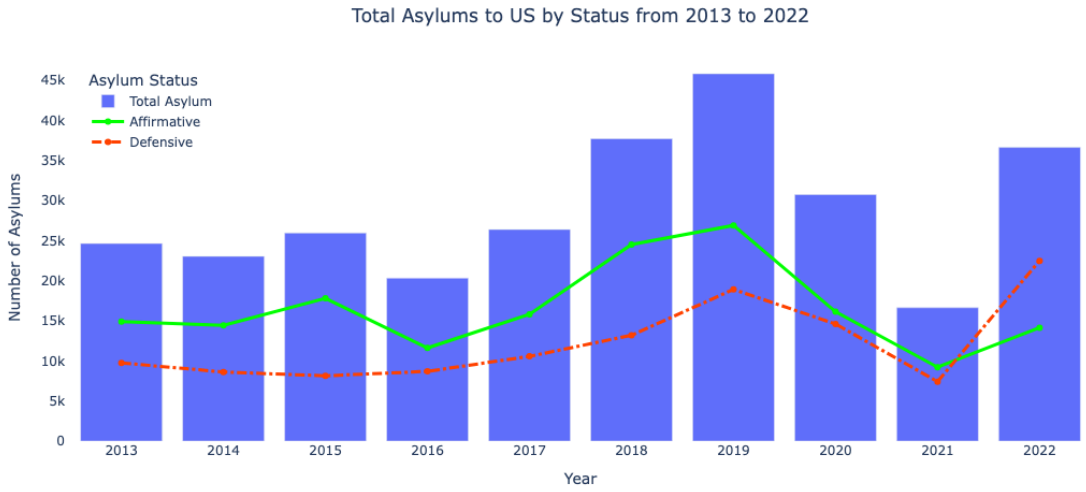


Figure 3. U.S. asylum grants by affirmative and defensive route, FY2013–2022. Reproduced from notebook Figure 6, using OHSS tables 17d and 19d. Bars equal the sum of the two lines. The notebook chart says "asylums"; the measure is grants.

China and Asia Asylum Comparison

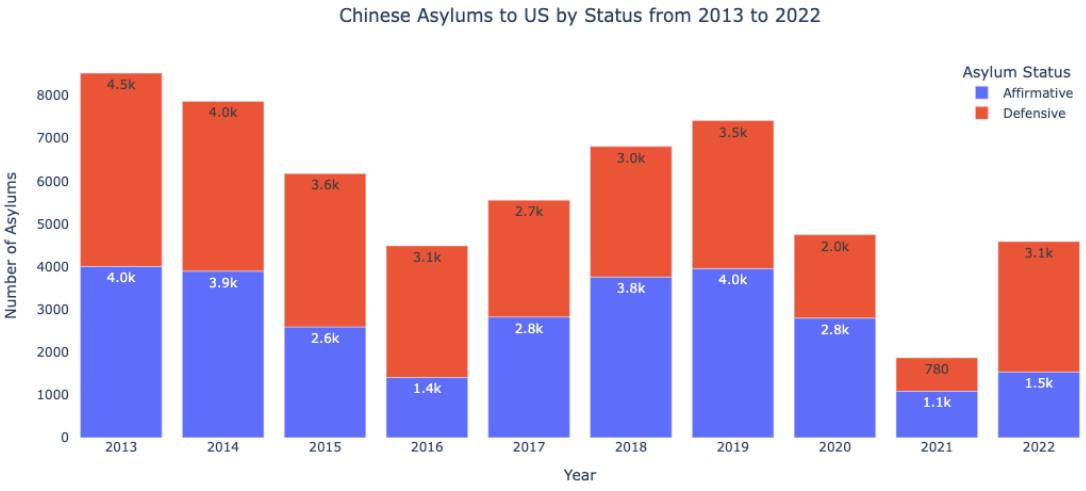


Figure 4. China nationality asylum grants by route, FY2013–2022. Reproduced from notebook Figure 7, using OHSS tables 17d and 19d. Stacked bars add affirmative and defensive grants; labels show rounded counts.

China's grants fell from 8,526 in FY2013 to 4,488 in FY2016, a 47.4% decline. Defensive grants led in FY2013–2016 and FY2022; affirmative grants led in FY2017–2021. Human Rights Watch documents the 2015 "709" crackdown on rights lawyers. It occurred during the decline, but grant totals cannot show whether it changed asylum filings or approvals.

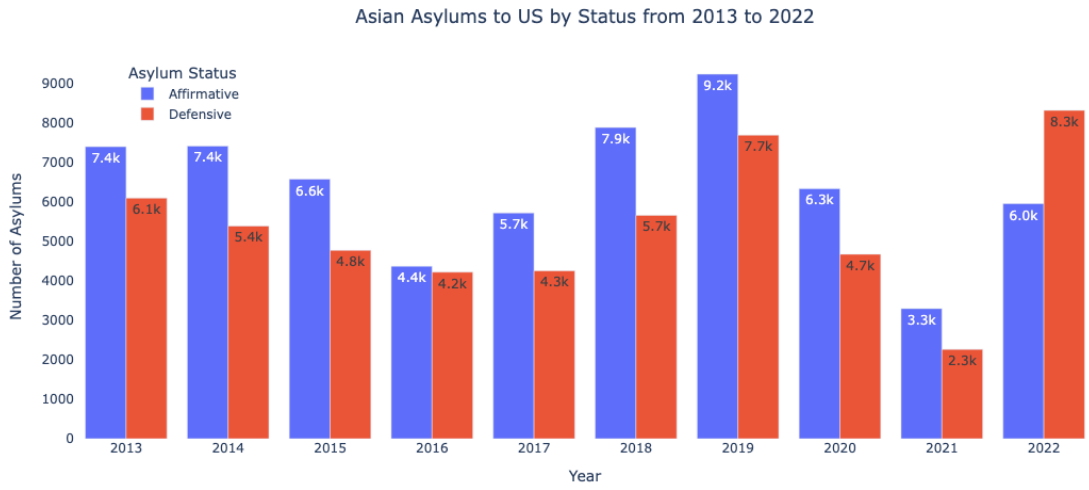


Figure 5. Asia nationality asylum grants by route, FY2013–2022. Reproduced from notebook Figure 8, using OHSS tables 17d and 19d. Grouped bars show each route separately; China is included within Asia. The vertical scale differs from Figure 4.

Asia's total grants changed from 13,483 in FY2013 to 14,264 in FY2022. Within that total, China fell from 8,526 to 4,589, while other Asian nationalities together rose from 4,957 to 9,675. China's share therefore fell from 63.2% to 32.2%. In FY2022, defensive grants exceeded affirmative grants for both China (3,051 versus 1,538) and Asia overall (8,313 versus 5,951). The FY2022 China grant share of all U.S. grants was 12.5% (4,589 / 36,615); that denominator is different from the FY2022 permanent residence class percentages.

Refugee Arrivals

The notebook dashboard compares China's small refugee count with national and Asian arrivals. From FY2016 to FY2018, U.S. arrivals fell from 84,989 to 22,405; Asian arrivals fell from 48,268 to 7,524.

Asian arrivals fell 84.4%, faster than the 73.6% national decline, so Asia's share fell from 56.8% to 33.6%; it reached 37.1% in FY2022. This share change is more specific than saying that all refugee arrivals declined. China had 102 arrivals in FY2013, 6 in FY2018, and 8 in FY2022; FY2019 was withheld.

The presidential refugee ceiling was set at 110,000 for FY2017 and 45,000 for FY2018. A lower ceiling is a relevant constraint on the overall program, but actual arrivals were below both limits, and a global limit does not explain which nationalities made up the arrivals. Applications, referrals, and screening outcomes would be needed to investigate the Asian share change.

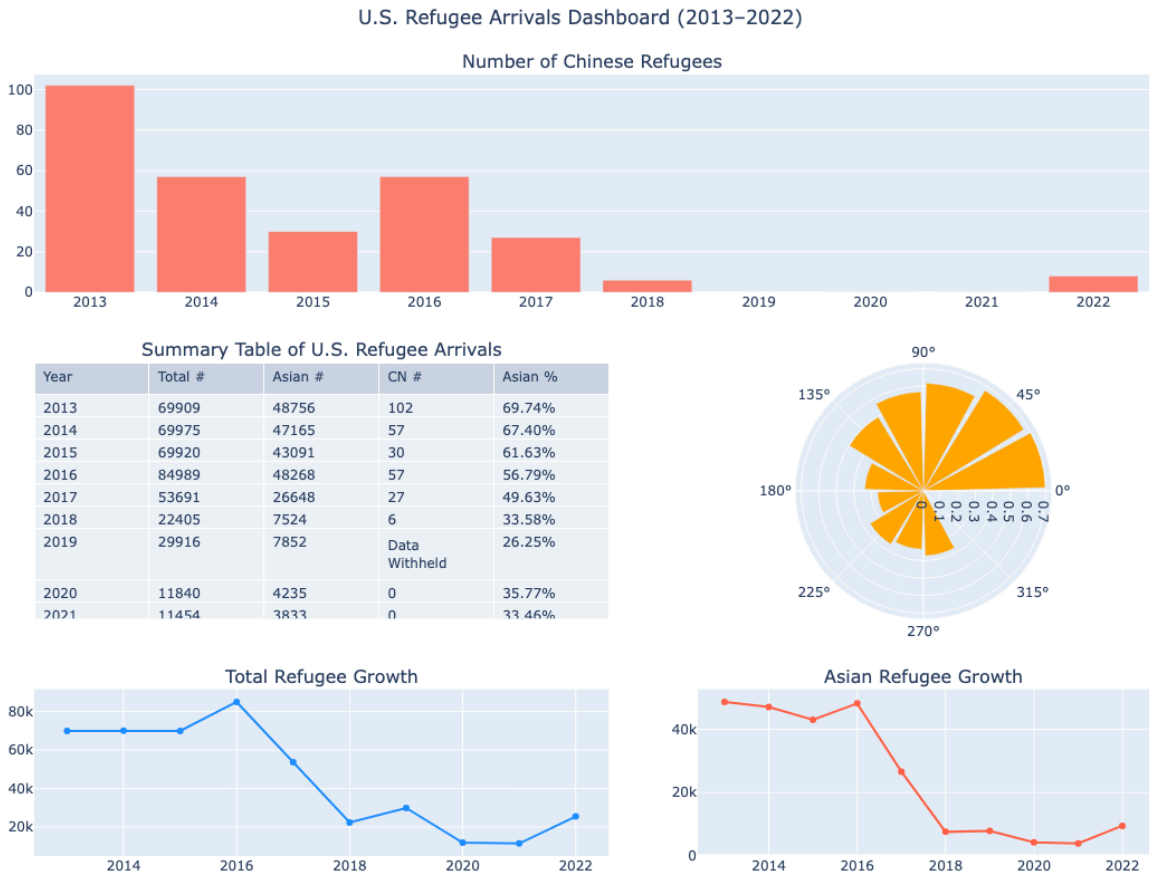


Figure 6. Refugee arrivals by nationality, FY2013–2022. Reproduced from notebook Figure 5, using OHSS table 14d. Top: China counts; center: year table and Asia's share (radial scale is a fraction); bottom: U.S. and Asia counts. "Data Withheld" is not zero.

Findings and Limitations

Permanent residence. China's count fell from 133,139 in the 1870s to 15,268 in the 1890s, a span including the 1882 Chinese Exclusion Act. The 1965 repeal of national origins quotas frames the later rise, but these tables cannot isolate either law's effect.

Admission mix and shares. Employment preferences were 44.9% for China born residents versus 26.5% nationally in FY2022. China's FY2021–2022 count rose while its U.S. share fell from 6.496% to 6.090% as the national total grew faster.

Refugee arrivals. Asian arrivals fell 84.4% versus 73.6% nationally in FY2016–2018. The FY2018 ceiling was lower, but actual arrivals fell below it; the ceiling alone cannot explain Asia's shrinking share.

Asylum grants. China's share of Asian grants fell from 63.2% to 32.2% in FY2013–2022. The 2018 interview order change and 2020 service pause provide context for national trends, but grant totals cannot identify their effects.

These are descriptive findings. Without applications, denials, case histories, or policy exposure, the tables cannot test causation. Geographic definitions and periods differ, and withheld cells are not zeros.

Sources

OHSS Yearbook 2022, tables 1, 2, 10d, 14d, 17d, 19d

National Archives, Chinese Exclusion Act · State Department, 1924 Act · National Archives, 1965 Act

Federal Register, FY2017 ceiling · Federal Register, FY2018 ceiling · Human Rights Watch, 709 crackdown

USCIS, 2018 interview scheduling · USCIS, March 2020 service suspension · USCIS, FY2021 annual report

Notebook: Alaina_immigration_analysis_final.ipynb; Figures 1–6 use saved outputs from cells 9, 30, 48, 51, 54, 40.